



HAMSTER · MESOCRICETUS AURATUS

Keep your hamster the right way from day one.

A complete, fact-checked printable manual: the enclosure the starter kit isn't, bedding deep enough to burrow in, wet tail recognized on sight, the law in every state, and the routines that make a short life a good one.

INSIDE

- ✓ Every size in inches and centimeters, with floor space and wheel size by species
- ✓ The bedding depth study, with the three numbers that reorder everything
- ✓ Wet tail on its own page, because it can kill in 24 to 48 hours
- ✓ Emergency card, pet-sitter sheet, owner logs and a torpor guide

47 pages

Beginner

Print or tablet

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CONTENTS

What's inside

Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

GETTING STARTED

How to Use This Package	3
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SECTION 01 · PROFILE

Quick Profile & Cost Overview	4
The Species, Size & Lifespan	5

SECTION 02 · HOUSING & ENVIRONMENT

Enclosure Size, Bar Spacing & Where It Goes	6
Bedding Depth & the Study Behind It	7
Temperature, Humidity & Light	8
The Wheel, the Sand Bath & the Furnishings	9
Cleaning & Hygiene	10

SECTION 03 · FEEDING

Diet, the Schedule & Weaning	11
Fresh Foods, Hay & Protein	12
Treats & the Never-Feed List	13
Water & Why a Hamster Stops Eating	14
Growth, Weight, Body Condition & Aging	15

SECTION 04 · HANDLING & BEHAVIOR

Handling & Taming	16
Normal Behavior & Body Language	17
Enrichment & Common Mistakes	18

SECTION 05 · ARRIVAL & LIFE STAGES

Choosing a Species & Housing Company	19
A Healthy Hamster, the First Days & the First Vet Visit	20
Sexing, Breeding & Litters	21
Torpor: Cold, Short Days & Telling It From Death	22

SECTION 06 · THE LAW

Is a Hamster Legal Where You Live?	23
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SECTION 07 · HEALTH & COMMON ISSUES

Red Flags & Finding a Vet	24
Wet Tail	25
Overgrown Incisors & Cheek Pouch Problems	26
Tumors, Skin Problems & Diabetes	27
Respiratory Infection & Heat Stress	28
Antibiotics: Ask Before the First Dose	29
Reading the Signs, Hydration & Germs You Can Catch	30

SECTION 08 · QUICK REFERENCE

Setup Checklist & Targets	31
Emergency & Quick Targets Card	32

SECTION 09 · OWNER TOOLS

Budget: Setup & Shopping List	33
Budget: Yearly Costs & the Vet	34
First 30 Days	35
Symptom Quick Reference	36
Daily, Weekly & Seasonal Routine	37
Power Outages, Heat Waves, Travel & Transport	38
Pet-Sitter Sheet	39
Owner Log	40
Equipment & Vet Log	41
Enrichment Checklist & Log	42

REFERENCE

Glossary, A to H	43
Glossary, I to Z	44
Sources	45
Where the Sources Disagree	46
Version History & About	47

START HERE

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

UNITS USED THROUGHOUT

Every temperature and size is given twice: degrees Fahrenheit (°F) with degrees Celsius (°C), and inches (in) and square inches (sq in) with centimeters (cm) and square centimeters (cm²), and bar gaps in millimeters (mm). A hamster is weighed in grams (g), with ounces (oz) beside it, and its water is measured in milliliters (ml). Humidity is a percentage (%) of the moisture the air could hold. Prices are in United States dollars.

If you haven't set up yet

Check the law first, on page 23: a hamster is legal in nearly every state, but two are exceptions. Then read the housing pages, starting at page 6, in order before buying anything. The enclosure and the bedding are expensive to redo, and the pet-shop starter kit gets both wrong: too small for the floor space and too shallow for the bedding. Buy the enclosure once, using the Budget & Shopping List on page 33, and buy it bigger than the kit.

If your hamster is already home

Audit what you have against the Setup Checklist below, starting with bedding depth, the highest-value change available. If your hamster chews the bars, that is a readout of the housing, not a personality trait. And if its rear end is wet or matted, stop reading and go to page 25: a same-day emergency.

Print these first

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ Page 31: Setup Checklist & Targets | ☐ Page 39: Pet-Sitter Sheet |
| ☐ Page 32: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 40: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 36: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 41: Equipment & Vet Log |
| ☐ Page 37: Daily, Weekly & Seasonal Routine | ☐ Page 42: Enrichment Checklist & Log |

WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

Starter-kit cages fall well short of current welfare recommendations. This package reflects current guidance, cross-checked against the sources on page 45.

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

A veterinarian who sees small mammals. This is a husbandry reference for day-to-day care. Anything urgent is a vet call, not a page in this book, and in a hamster the same day matters. Find a vet who sees hamsters before you need one. Nothing on the law page is legal advice either.

SECTION 01 · PROFILE

Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail.

Scientific name	<i>Mesocricetus auratus</i> for the Syrian or golden hamster; the dwarfs are mostly <i>Phodopus</i>
Adult size	Syrian 5 to 7 in (13 to 18 cm) and 3 to 5 oz (85 to 140 g). Every dwarf stays under 100 g
Lifespan	Syrians 2 to 3 years, Winter Whites often about 1. Median age at death in a large study: 1.75 years
Native range	Northern Syria and southern Turkey: arid steppe and farmland, in extensive burrows
Diet type	Omnivore. A complete pellet or lab block as the staple, small amounts of fresh food, and protein treats (page 11)
Floor space minimum	700 to 775 sq in (4,500 to 5,000 cm ²) unbroken for a Syrian, around 600 sq in (3,900 cm ²) for a dwarf
The one hard rule	Bedding deep enough to burrow in: 6 in (15 cm) is the floor, and the research used 40 cm (page 7)
Temperature	65 to 75°F (18 to 24°C), held steady. No heat lamp and no UVB (ultraviolet B light)
Housing	One per enclosure for a Syrian or Chinese hamster; some dwarfs can share (page 19)
Active hours	Mainly nocturnal. Waking one by day is the commonest way owners get bitten (page 16)
Legal status	Legal in 48 states, the District of Columbia and New York City. Hawaii bans it, and Oregon's rule is unclear
Conservation status	Endangered on the IUCN (International Union for Conservation of Nature) global threatened-species list, for the wild Syrian population

Cost overview

The animal and the setup

About \$25 for a Syrian, \$15 to \$25 for a dwarf. \$165 to \$550 to set up, animal included, with every item priced: \$185 to \$550 with a Syrian, \$165 to \$430 with a dwarf. Every line is on page 33.

Monthly ongoing

\$10 to \$25 for food, vegetables, bedding, chews, bath sand and hay, or \$140 to \$265 a year. Most of it is bedding.

BUDGET FOR THE VET TOO

A small-mammal wellness exam runs about \$80 to \$115, and an emergency exam about \$200 before any tests or treatment. Wet tail is the one to plan for.

Fun facts worth knowing

- Nearly every pet Syrian descends from one litter: the species was brought into captivity from a single wild-caught female found near Aleppo, Syria, in 1930.
- Cheek pouches stretch back as far as the shoulders and can hold roughly a fifth of the hamster's own body weight, which is why a day without seeing it eat may be nothing.

The species, size & lifespan

What you are buying, how big it gets, and how long it stays.

Five pet species

Five species are kept as pets: the Syrian (the largest and the most common), the Winter White, the Campbell's, the Chinese and the Roborovski. The Winter White, Campbell's and Roborovski are the "dwarfs" of the pet trade, and the Chinese hamster is sold alongside them though it does not share their tolerance for company. Temperament varies more by species than most people expect: a Syrian and a Roborovski, both sold under the same label, are genuinely different pets to hold. Where the species differ, the page says which one it means.

In the wild a Syrian is a solitary burrower that digs extensive tunnel systems and is fiercely territorial toward other hamsters, a trait that carries into captivity and is why a Syrian lives alone as an adult.

Size

SPECIES	ADULT LENGTH	WEIGHT
Syrian (golden)	5 to 7 in (13 to 18 cm)	3 to 5 oz (85 to 140 g), females heavier than males
Chinese	4 to 5 in (10 to 13 cm)	Under 100 g
Winter White and Campbell's	2 to 4 in (5 to 10 cm)	Under 100 g
Roborovski	1.5 to 2 in (4 to 5 cm)	Under 100 g

Varieties

Color and coat vary: short-haired, long-haired, satin and curly "rex". They rarely change the price, and this is not a species with morph-driven pricing. The one care difference is the coat: some long-haired hamsters need weekly brushing to take out mats, bedding and debris.

Lifespan

Syrian and Roborovski	2 to 3 years
Chinese	1.5 to 3 years
Winter White	Often only about 12 months
Median across all pet hamsters	1.75 years at death, in a large veterinary study of hamsters under veterinary care, with the range reaching about 3.65 years
Elderly from	1.5 years. From about 2.5 years expect overgrown nails, hair loss, more sleeping and drinking, and slower movement (page 15)

A SHORT COMMITMENT, AND A SHORT MARGIN

That is brief next to almost any other pet. It cuts both ways: less time to spread the setup cost across, but less total expense, and a much smaller commitment to take on. It also leaves little room for wait-and-see with a health problem, which is why the health section is built around same-day action.

Enclosure size, bar spacing & where it goes

Bigger than the starter kit, and the first thing to get right because it is expensive to redo.

Floor space

Current welfare guidance calls for a genuinely large, unbroken floor, with more always better. A Syrian needs roughly 700 to 775 sq in (4,500 to 5,000 cm²), and a dwarf species around 600 sq in (3,900 cm²). A 40-gallon breeder tank suits a dwarf, and a Syrian does better in something larger still, such as a 75-gallon tank or its equivalent. Buy the right size once instead of planning to upgrade later.

	SYRIAN	DWARF (WINTER WHITE, CAMPBELL'S, ROBOROVSKI, CHINESE)
Unbroken floor	700 to 775 sq in (4,500 to 5,000 cm ²)	About 600 sq in (3,900 cm ²)
Tank equivalent	75 gallons or similar	40-gallon breeder
Wire bar spacing, at most	1/2 in (13 mm)	1/4 in (6 mm), tighter for a Roborovski

Types of enclosure

A bin, a wire cage or a glass tank can all work. Whichever you choose, it has to hold the bedding depth that hamsters need, and that is where most commercial cages fail: they cannot physically hold the depth, which makes cage choice and bedding depth the same decision. A wire cage needs bar spacing no wider than the figures above, because a Roborovski especially can squeeze through surprisingly small gaps.

Where the cage goes

- A quiet area, away from running water and from other pets.
- A room where the lights go off at about the same time each night, because a hamster is active at night and needs a routine.
- Not a bedroom. A hamster is noisy when it wakes.
- Away from drafts, since a draft or damp bedding is a bigger cold risk than a cool room.
- Not right beside another hamster's cage, and not near the cage of any other rodent, because their active hours differ and each disturbs the other.

NEVER

Buy the starter kit and plan to upgrade later. The classic small wire cage falls well short of current welfare recommendations for floor space and for bedding. Also never house two Syrians in one enclosure, in any size (page 19).

WHAT THE CAGE COSTS

The enclosure is the biggest line in the setup: budget \$30 to \$250 for a Syrian, from a large bin up to a ready-made 47-inch cage, and \$30 to \$150 for a dwarf, where a 40-gallon breeder tank is the priciest choice. Go bigger than a basic kit offers. The price is the reason the animal is the cheapest part of keeping a hamster properly.

Bedding depth & the study behind it

The single highest-value thing you can change, and the one no starter kit can accommodate.

What to use

Dust-free paper-based bedding or aspen shavings. Mixing a burrow-holding material with a looser one helps tunnels stay up instead of collapsing, which is what separates a hamster that digs from one that just redecorates. Avoid cedar and pine entirely: the aromatic oils in both irritate the respiratory system. Never use cotton-style fluffy nesting material, which wraps around limbs.

How deep

DEPTH	WHAT IT GETS YOU
6 in (15 cm)	The minimum, and a welfare requirement rather than decoration. This is the floor, not the target.
8 in (20 cm) or more	Better, because it leaves room for a deeper layer.
4 in (10 cm)	The shallow group in the study: significantly more wire-gnawing and higher wheel running.
40 cm, about 15 in	The depth at which every hamster in the study built a burrow and used it. The number to aim for.
40 to 80 cm, about 15 to 31 in	The range the researchers concluded seemed to improve welfare.
80 cm, about 31 in	The deepest group, in which wire-gnawing was not observed at all.

THE STUDY, IN THREE NUMBERS

Researchers assigned 45 male golden hamsters to groups with 80, 40 or 10 cm of wood shavings and measured their behavior, including responses to acute stressors. Hamsters on 10 cm gnawed the cage wire significantly more and ran the wheel harder than the others. Every hamster given 40 cm or more built a burrow and used it, with significantly less gnawing. In the 80 cm group, no wire-gnawing was seen. Depth is the enrichment, and everything else is secondary to it.

Why it matters in practice

- Wire-gnawing is one of the standard behavioral measures of housing quality in small rodents. A hamster that chews the bars is reporting on the setup, and in a shallow cage it is a depth problem before it is a toy problem.
- The commercial default is nowhere near 40 cm, and most cages sold for hamsters cannot hold it. Choose the enclosure by how much bedding it can carry.
- Heavy wheel running is not proof the setup works. The hamsters on shallow bedding ran more.

WHAT IT COSTS

A starting load of paper bedding runs \$15 to \$35, and replacing it through the year runs \$60 to \$100. Bedding is the largest share of the monthly cost, and the reason the monthly figure is not zero.

Temperature, humidity & light

No heat lamp, no UVB, and one cold threshold that genuinely matters.

READING	WHAT IT MEANS
65 to 75°F (18 to 24°C)	The comfortable range, kept stable. A normal indoor room needs no supplemental heat.
Below 65°F (18°C)	Out of range. Appetite and activity start to drop.
Below about 41°F (5°C)	A hamster can slip into torpor, a hibernation-like state that can be dangerous, especially with short days. It does not fatten up first, so one that fails to wake to eat can starve (page 22).
Above 80°F (27°C)	Heat stress. A hamster cannot cool itself like a person, and the room is the whole climate system.
Humidity 40 to 60%	The target for the room.

Keeping it steady

- A digital thermometer and humidity gauge in the room turn "seems fine" into a reading. A hamster is too small to judge by how the room feels to you.
- Cold is less dangerous than heat in most rooms, but a draft or damp bedding is the realistic cold risk. Keep the cage out of drafts and keep the bedding dry.
- In a hot spell, move the cage to the coolest room with some air movement, and keep fresh water in front of it.
- Below 41°F, keep the room warmer. This is the one hard floor for the species.

Lighting

No special lighting and no UVB is needed. A normal day and night cycle is enough. The thing to remember is that this is a nocturnal species: bright light during its active hours is more disruptive than helpful, so a lamp left on over the cage in the evening is working against the animal. Put the cage in a room where the lights go off at about the same time each night.

TORPOR IS NOT HIBERNATION

Pet hamsters do not undergo true hibernation. What cold produces is torpor, which can look alarmingly like death.

The wheel, the sand bath & the furnishings

Four items that are essentials, not extras.

The wheel: solid, and sized to the species

SPECIES	WHEEL DIAMETER
Syrian	8 to 11 in (20 to 28 cm)
Dwarf	6 to 8 in (15 to 20 cm)

A solid running surface with no rungs is essential, because wire and mesh wheels cause foot injuries. A wheel that is too small forces an arched running posture that is hard on the spine over time, so a Syrian should run with a flat back. The caveat comes from the bedding study: the hamsters on shallow bedding ran more, so heavy wheel use is not a welfare score. Provide the wheel, and do not read the odometer.

The sand bath

A dust-free, non-clumping sand bath is a genuine species essential. A hamster works coat and skin oils out in it the way a bird uses a dust bath, and it is also where most hamsters choose to toilet, which does more for hygiene than any amount of bedding changes. Use a shallow dish heavy enough that the hamster cannot tip it and deep enough to roll in. Sift the sand when you spot-clean, and replace it when it clumps or smells. Chinchilla bathing dust is a far finer powder that irritates the eyes and airways, so it is the wrong product.

Hides, cover and tunnels

A hideout is not optional: a hamster with nowhere to hide is a chronically stressed one. Hamsters are prey animals and cross open ground reluctantly, so connected cover, buried tunnel sections and scattered hides change how much of the enclosure gets used at all. A large cage the animal will not cross is a small cage.

The rest of the list

- **Water:** a bottle with a valveless sipper tube, checked daily for leaks, or a bowl. Never a glass tube for a Syrian, which bites through glass (page 14).
- **Food dish,** though much of the food is better scattered (page 12).
- **Chew items,** because a lack of them is the usual reason the front teeth overgrow (page 26).
- **A digital thermometer and humidity gauge,** for the room.
- **A kitchen scale in grams,** for the weight checks.

Cleaning & hygiene

Spot daily, deep less often, and never a total strip-out.

A hamster's cage smells of its own scent marks and its food stores, and a cleaning routine has to keep enough of both to leave the animal settled.

HOW OFTEN	WHAT TO DO
Daily	Remove soiled bedding and uneaten fresh food. Wash and rinse the water bottle or bowl, and check the sipper for leaks.
Weekly, small cage	Move the hamster to a carrier. Take out the bedding, wash the cage and accessories with a small-animal habitat cleaner, rinse off every trace of it, and let everything dry fully before fresh bedding goes in.
Every few weeks, large deep-bedded enclosure	The same full clean, with spot cleaning in between. Deep bedding is replaced regularly to stay clean and dust free.
Every time	Set aside a handful of clean nesting material and any dry food hoard, and put them back afterward. Leave an established burrow in place during spot cleans.

DO NOT STRIP IT OUT

A total strip-out erases the scent marks and the hoard at once, and it can leave a hamster unsettled for days. Return the nest, wheel and bowls to the same spots, since a hamster relies on the layout staying put. Clean in the evening, once the hamster is already awake.

The sand bath and the latrine corner

Most hamsters toilet in the sand bath, so sifting it when you spot-clean does more than any amount of bedding changes. Replace the sand when it clumps or smells.

Washing your hands

Small mammals can carry germs that make people ill, and pet food, equipment and bedding can carry them too. Wash your hands with soap and running water after handling the hamster or its bedding. Keep the hamster and its equipment out of the kitchen and anywhere food is prepared, stored or eaten, and clean its supplies outside the home if you can. Children under 5 are more likely than anyone to get sick from small-animal germs, and a bite or scratch can spread germs even if the wound does not look deep. Page 30 covers the one germ specific to hamsters.

POOR HYGIENE AND WET TAIL

Poor hygiene is one of the triggers of wet tail, the biggest threat to the species. Spot-cleaning the soiled corner daily is cheap insurance, and it does not disturb the burrow.

Diet, the schedule & weaning

One staple, a disputed schedule, and a few firm numbers around it.

The staple

A nutritionally complete, species-appropriate hamster pellet or lab block (a formulated complete diet pressed into a block), not a loose seed mix on its own. Given a mix, a hamster picks out the sugary, fatty bits and leaves the fiber-rich pieces, which contributes to dental problems and obesity. A strict seed-only diet is too high in fat and nutritionally poor. Hamsters are genuinely omnivorous, so small amounts of fresh food and protein sit alongside the staple.

The schedule is a real disagreement

There is no single right schedule, and both approaches are legitimate. Pick one and stay consistent, with fresh water always available either way.

APPROACH	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE
Always available	Pelleted food stays in the cage all the time. Hamsters naturally hoard surplus and rarely overeat.
Twice-daily meals	Measured feedings with a daily target: roughly 2 tablespoons for a standard-size hamster and about 1 tablespoon for a dwarf. A broader range of 1/8 to 1/3 cup shows up elsewhere.

The firmer numbers

FOOD	HOW MUCH
Fresh vegetables	About 1 teaspoon a day
Fruit	About 1 teaspoon, roughly 3 times a week
All fresh food together	Vegetables and fruit combined, under about 10% of the diet
Treats: seeds, nuts, popcorn	1 to 2 times a week, under 5 to 10% of the total
Timothy hay	A chewing supplement, not the diet base the way it is for a rabbit

Diet by age

- **Pups:** weaned at about 20 days, and as late as 3 to 4 weeks by some counts. Syrian pups are the group wet tail hits hardest, between 3 and 10 weeks old, so a sudden diet change is the last thing a weaned pup needs (page 25).
- **A new hamster:** stays on the food it was already eating. Any change is made over about ten days, a little of the new food mixed into the old.
- **Adults:** the staple, the small fresh amounts above, and scattered food in place of a full bowl.
- **Dwarf species prone to diabetes:** the sugar rules matter more, since Campbell's and Chinese hamsters have a documented high susceptibility.

Fresh foods, hay & protein

Small daily amounts, scattered rather than served.

FOOD	TIER	NOTES
Complete hamster pellet or lab block	STAPLE	The base of the diet, plain and formulated.
Broccoli, cucumber, bell pepper, kale, spinach, peas, zucchini, carrot	DAILY	About 1 teaspoon a day, vegetables first. Remove any uneaten fresh food each day.
Timothy hay	FREELY	Encourages the chewing that wears down continuously growing teeth. A supplement, not the base.
Mealworms, boiled unseasoned egg	PROTEIN	Animal and insect protein reflects the wild diet. Small amounts, as treats.
Apple with seeds removed, banana, melon, pear	3x A WEEK	About 1 teaspoon. Extra caution with diabetes-prone dwarfs.

Scatter it, don't serve it

Hamsters are genuinely omnivorous in the wild and eat insects, so mealworms or a little boiled egg are a reflection of the natural diet rather than an indulgence. Scatter or hide food around the cage instead of relying only on a bowl: it encourages the natural foraging and hoarding behavior that is core to the species, and it turns a two-minute event into a foraging session that costs nothing.

Cheek pouches and caches

A hamster's cheek pouches can hold roughly a fifth of its own body weight and stretch back as far as the shoulders. It carries food away and caches it around the enclosure, so you may not see it eat for a day or more while it quietly works through a stash. That is different from a hamster visibly refusing fresh food that is on offer.

KEEP THE HOARD WHEN YOU CLEAN

Set aside any dry food hoard and put it back after cleaning. Removing it all at once is one of the ways a clean unsettles a hamster for days (page 10).

WHAT THIS COSTS

Pellets or lab blocks run about \$30 to \$50 a year and vegetables about \$20 to \$40. Most of the monthly cost is bedding, not food.

Treats & the never-feed list

Safe in moderation, then the foods to keep away entirely. Some entries are disputed, and the table says which.

FOOD	TIER	NOTES
Nuts and seeds, plain pasta, unsalted popcorn	TREAT	1 to 2 times a week, under 5 to 10% of the diet.
Grapes	NEVER	Poisonous to rodents.
Rhubarb	NEVER	Poisonous to rodents.
Raw onion, raw garlic	NEVER	Real risk of hemolytic anemia (the red blood cells break down). Small cooked amounts may be lower-risk, but treat that exception cautiously, not as confirmed.
Chocolate	NEVER	Named as unsafe.
Bitter almonds	NEVER	Different from common sweet almonds, a frequent point of confusion.
Raw kidney beans, raw potato, eggplant	NEVER	All named as unsafe.
Avocado	NEVER	Named as unsafe.
Sugary treats, honey sticks, fruit-heavy diets	AVOID	The typical route to diabetes in the dwarf species prone to it.
Citrus	DISPUTED	Disputed: some avoid it entirely, and others say occasional citrus is fine for a Syrian, with extra caution for diabetes-prone dwarfs. Nothing is lost by leaving it out.

SOFT OR MOIST FOODS AND THE CHEEK POUCH

Soft or moist food can clump and lodge in a cheek pouch. If one side of the face stays swollen, the hamster paws at its face or drools, or it suddenly stops collecting food, that needs a vet (page 26).

THE SUGAR RULE IS NOT COSMETIC

Dwarf hamsters are more prone to diabetes, with excessive drinking and urination alongside weight loss. Sugary treats, honey sticks and fruit-heavy diets are the typical culprits, so avoid them as a matter of course instead of waiting for symptoms. A plain, formulated pellet or lab block as the diet base is the simplest way to avoid feeding into the risk (page 27).

Water & why a hamster stops eating

Cheek pouches make this harder to read than it looks.

Water

Fresh water must be there all the time, from a bottle with a valveless sipper tube, checked daily for leaks. A hamster drinks about 9 to 12 ml a day (about 2 teaspoons), so a bottle that has barely moved in a day is worth a look at the spout. Glass water tubes are the wrong choice for a Syrian, which bites through glass.

Why a hamster stops eating

- 1. **Dental problems.** The single most common cause. Overgrown or broken front teeth make chewing painful, so it avoids food even while hungry (page 26).
- 2. **Wet tail.** A bacterial gut infection that can be fatal within 24 to 48 hours if untreated. Appetite loss is an early sign, alongside a soiled, wet rear end (page 25).
- 3. **Cold-induced torpor.** Below about 41°F (5°C), particularly with short days, with minimal activity and little or no eating (page 22).
- 4. **Stress.** A new environment, handling or cage changes cause a temporary, lower-urgency dip.
- 5. **Respiratory infection or other illness,** usually with labored breathing, discharge or lethargy alongside.
- 6. **Diabetes** in predisposed dwarf species, as appetite and energy changes.
- 7. **Cheek pouch impaction.** Uncommon, but soft or moist food can lodge in a pouch.

When to worry

ELAPSED WITHOUT EATING	WHAT TO DO
6 to 12 hours, otherwise active	Worth watching. Check the cache and the water bottle.
12 to 24 hours, or any refusal with lethargy or diarrhea	Call the vet.
24 hours with no food intake at all	Critical, given how fast a hamster's metabolism runs.
48 hours or more	Life-threatening.

SEE A VET NOW, WHATEVER THE HOUR COUNT

Labored breathing or wheezing · wet or soiled hindquarters · discharge from the eyes or nose · a swollen abdomen · seizures · noticeable weight loss · a hunched, lethargic posture. Any of these alongside refused food skips the table above.

Growth, weight, body condition & aging

A hamster's life is short, so the stages come fast.

Weight

A healthy adult Syrian weighs roughly 3 to 5 oz (85 to 140 g), females heavier than males, and every dwarf species stays under 100 g. A kitchen scale and a small container make a weigh-in a thirty-second job, and a steady number is the plainest sign of a hamster that is eating and well. Weigh it regularly and write the number in the log on page 40, because an unexpected gain or loss is often the first thing that changes. A hamster has a high metabolic rate and loses condition quickly once it is unwell.

Reading condition

A sick hamster often isolates itself and can show weight loss, a hunched posture, lethargy, rough fur and labored breathing. A healthy one has clean, clear, bright eyes and a clean coat with no fur loss, flaky skin, scratches or wounds. Check the body for lumps, bumps and scabs while you weigh.

Life stages

AGE	WHAT IT MEANS
About 20 days	Pups are weaned (as late as 3 to 4 weeks by some counts).
3 to 10 weeks	The window in which wet tail hits young Syrians hardest. Keep stress, transport and diet changes to a minimum.
7 to 8 weeks	A Syrian can breed. Sex is worth checking before this age (page 21).
1.5 years	A hamster counts as elderly.
About 2.5 years and older	Overgrown nails, hair loss, more sleeping and drinking, and slower movement.

Aging

Tumors are common in older hamsters, particularly females, and can grow quickly given how fast a hamster's metabolism runs. A lump anywhere always warrants a vet visit. A hamster that digs and runs wears its own nails down, so there is no trim schedule, only a check for overgrowth in an older or less active animal.

FOOD AND CONDITION

Diet sits behind several problems: obesity, diabetes in dwarf species, and the diarrhea that follows a sudden food change. A plain staple, small fresh amounts and treats kept to 1 to 2 times a week protect the weight you are measuring.

Handling & taming

Most hamster bites are not a mean pet. They are a startled, disoriented nocturnal animal defending itself.

THE COMMONEST WAY OWNERS GET BITTEN

Reaching into the cage during the day while the hamster is deeply asleep. From the hamster's side that is an ambush, not a greeting. Let it know you are there, and wake it gently and slowly before you try to touch it.

The pickup

- Approach calmly and let the hamster wake up and orient itself before you reach in. Evening, once it is up, goes far better than daytime.
- Let it investigate your hands in its own time. Then cup it between two hands and open them so it sits on your joined palms.
- Scoop from below. Never grab from above, and never corner or trap one that is trying to get away.
- Stay low, over something soft, and hold it no more than a few inches over a table or the floor. A hamster is quick, and a fall can injure it.
- Do not handle one that is resting or sleeping unless it is necessary.

Taming, on the hamster's clock

Set the cage up before collecting the hamster, with a handful of its used, dry bedding moved in so the place smells familiar. Leave it alone for the first 24 hours apart from food, water and a look for any sign of illness or injury. Then, in the evening once it is up and active:

1. **Hand in the cage, no touching.** Rest a hand inside so your smell and presence become ordinary.
2. **Floor sessions.** In a secure room, sit on the floor and put a short tunnel in front of the hamster. Let it walk through and come out to investigate you. For the first few weeks, let it walk over your hands and sit in your lap.
3. **Stop while it is calm.** Put it back while it is still relaxed, not once it gets irritable, or it learns that fussing is how a session ends.
4. **Short lifts.** Once it is comfortable in your lap, practice cupping it up and setting it back down. After one to two weeks of this, most hamsters are happy to be picked up and hand fed.

A short session every day works better than long sessions at weekends with nothing in between.

Species matter

A Syrian is the easiest to tame and generally the least likely to nip once settled. Winter White, Campbell's and Chinese dwarfs are quicker and more easily startled, with a real chance of nipping when cornered. A Roborovski is the fastest and least suited to regular handling, and its tiny size and sudden movements make a drop likely, so most are better watched than held.

OUT OF THE CAGE

Time out is always supervised, in a pen or a hamster-proofed room with cables covered and no hazardous plants. Exercise balls are not recommended: they can be stressful, and the hamster cannot reach food, water or a hiding place while inside one.

Normal behavior & body language

What the hamster is doing, and what it is telling you.

WHAT YOU SEE	WHAT IT USUALLY MEANS
Packed cheeks, then a hidden stash in a corner	Normal hoarding. A hamster stores food in its cheek pouches and deposits it to eat later, so a day without seeing it eat can be nothing.
Asleep by day, active at dusk and after dark	A mainly nocturnal species, though it can be active for periods in the day. Handle it in the evening.
Running the wheel hard all night	Normal, and not a welfare score. Hamsters on shallow bedding ran more.
Chewing the cage wire	A housing readout. Check bedding depth before anything else, because the depth study found gnawing fell as depth rose.
Squeezing through a gap	A hamster is an excellent chewer and an escape artist and can flatten its body. Check bar spacing and every opening.
A bite when woken or grabbed	A startled, frightened animal. Hamsters typically bite when startled or frightened, or when restrained forcefully.
Rolling in the sand bath, then toileting there	Normal. The sand works coat and skin oils out, and most hamsters choose it as their toilet.
Repetitive behavior	A sign of stress. A stressed hamster is likely to become ill, so look at the setup and tell your vet if it continues.
Isolating itself, hunched, lethargic, rough fur	A sick or stressed animal. Weight loss and labored breathing can come with it. See page 24.

Nights, fights and company

Wild Syrians are solitary burrowers and fiercely territorial toward each other. Fights between hamsters happen at night, which is why a pair of any kind is checked for bite wounds every morning. Hamsters do not play-fight, so any real fight means permanent separation, with no attempt to reintroduce them.

What stress looks like in the setup

- A hamster with nowhere to hide is a chronically stressed one, so a hideout is not optional.
- Rough handling, a startled wake-up, a new environment and cage changes are the usual triggers.
- Stress and poor hygiene are directly linked to wet tail.

READING A BITE

A bite is nearly always information about the approach, not about the animal. Being woken suddenly, startled or handled roughly are the usual triggers, so change the approach, not the hamster.

Enrichment & common mistakes

Most small-pet enrichment advice is a list of things to buy. For hamsters, depth reorders the list.

Priority order

- 1. Bedding deep enough to hold a real burrow: 6 in (15 cm) as the floor, and 40 cm (about 15 in) or more where the cage allows (page 7).
- 2. A cage with the footprint and wall height to make that possible.
- 3. A correctly sized solid wheel.
- 4. Connected cover and buried tunnels, so the whole floor gets used.
- 5. Scatter feeding and foraging toys, instead of a bowl.
- 6. Novelty objects, last. They are the cheap part.

Common mistakes

MISTAKE	WHAT HAPPENS
Buying the starter kit	Too small for the floor space and too shallow for the bedding, and both are expensive to redo.
Shallow bedding	Significantly more wire-gnawing and higher wheel activity. What looks like personality is a housing readout.
Cedar or pine shavings	The aromatic oils irritate the respiratory system.
Cotton-style fluffy nesting material	Wraps around limbs.
A wire or mesh wheel, or one too small	Foot injuries from the surface, and an arched back from the size.
No sand bath	A species essential, so skipping it is not a minor omission.
An exercise ball	Stressful, and the hamster cannot reach food, water or a hiding place inside it.
Two Syrians in one enclosure	Fighting. One of the most common and preventable mistakes in hamster keeping.
A seed mix as the whole diet	The hamster eats the fatty bits and leaves the fiber. Obesity and dental disease follow.
Sugary treats and honey sticks	The typical culprits behind diabetes in dwarf species.
Reaching in during the day	The commonest way owners get bitten.
Waiting on a wet or matted rear end	Wet tail can be fatal within 24 to 48 hours.
Stripping the whole cage out	Erases the scent marks and the hoard and unsettles the hamster for days.

DO NOT READ THE ODOMETER

Heavy wheel use is not automatically a sign of a happy animal. The hamsters that ran most in the study were the ones on shallow bedding.

Choosing a species & housing company

Pick on what you want from the relationship, not on which one looked cutest.

SPECIES	HANDLING	COMPANY	WHAT TO KNOW
Syrian (golden)	Easiest	Always alone	Largest, easiest to tame, least likely to nip once settled. Strictly solitary: two together fight.
Winter White	Harder	Sometimes a same-sex pair	Quicker and easier to startle, with a real chance of a nip when cornered.
Campbell's	Harder	Sometimes a same-sex pair	The same, plus a documented high susceptibility to diabetes.
Chinese	Harder	Always alone	Sold alongside the dwarfs but does not share their tolerance for company. Also diabetes-prone.
Roborovski	Watch, don't hold	Sometimes a same-sex pair	The fastest and least suited to regular handling. A drop is likely.

If handling and interaction matter to you, choose a Syrian. If you mainly want an active pet to watch, a dwarf species, a Roborovski especially, fits that role better than regular handling. Neither is wrong, but picking on what you want out of the relationship matters more with hamsters than with most small pets. Rescues rehome hamsters too, and a Syrian costs about \$25 at a pet store chain while dwarfs run \$15 to \$25.

When dwarfs can share

Roborovski, Campbell's and Winter White dwarfs can sometimes share a cage as a pair or trio, when both of these hold:

- The group is one species and one sex, formed early in life, ideally from littermates.
- The cage is large, with plenty of enrichment and several shelters, so each hamster can reach food and water and get away from the others.

No new adult is added to an established group later. If it cannot be avoided, the two live in separate cages side by side for about a week first, and are not left together overnight until they have clearly settled. Unfamiliar hamsters otherwise should not live in cages side by side, since the scent of a stranger is stressful. The same goes for two males, or a male near a female.

NEVER HOUSE TWO SYRIANS TOGETHER

Syrians are strictly solitary, in any enclosure size. Buying "two for company" is one of the most common and preventable hamster-owner mistakes. Even a settled dwarf pair can fall out as it ages, so have a second cage ready before a pair ever comes home.

THE SAFE DEFAULT

None of these species needs company to be happy, and a single hamster is the safe default for all of them.

A healthy hamster, the first days & the first vet visit

Almost all of the early decisions are made before it comes home.

Choosing a healthy one

Look at the hamster in the evening, when it should be alert, active and interested in food.

CHECK	A HEALTHY HAMSTER
Eyes	Clean, clear and bright, with no cloudiness or discharge.
Teeth	Front teeth light yellow, smooth and wearing evenly.
Coat and skin	Clean, with no fur loss, flaky skin, scratches or wounds.
Breathing	No sneezing, wheezing or labored breathing.
Body	No lumps, bumps or scabs.
Rear end	Dry, with no stains or discharge. A wet or soiled bottom is the first sign of wet tail, which hits young Syrians hardest (page 25).

Before it comes home

- Set the cage up first, and move a handful of used, dry bedding from the old cage into the new one so the place smells familiar.
- Register with a local vet, so someone is on the list to call, and hand over the medical record you are given at collection as soon as you can.
- Put the cage in a quiet area, away from running water and other pets (page 6).

The first days

Leave the hamster alone for the first 24 hours, apart from food, water and a look for any sign of illness or injury. Keep it on the food it was already eating, and change anything gradually. Stress, transport, overcrowding, poor hygiene and a sudden diet change are the usual wet tail triggers, which is why the first days are for quiet. Then start the taming steps (page 16).

Keeping a new hamster apart

A new hamster lives alone in its own cage. Do not put it in a cage side by side with another hamster, or near another rodent's cage. For a single hamster the practical rule is to watch it closely for illness from the first day and to keep it away from other animals.

The first vet visit

A vet can confirm a hamster's sex at the first checkup, which matters because hamsters breed early and fast. It is also the moment to find out whether the practice sees rodents. A routine small-mammal wellness exam costs about \$80 to \$115.

PET SHOP AND BREEDER

Wet tail hits young Syrians of 3 to 10 weeks hardest, and a move to a new home is one of its triggers, so a young hamster is the one to watch most closely in the first weeks.

Sexing, breeding & litters

Hamsters breed early and fast, which is why it pays to know the sex.

Telling males from females

In an adult hamster the sex shows on the outside. Hold the hamster securely on its back in cupped hands and compare the gap between the anus and the genital opening: short in a female, clearly longer in a male. The testicles can be drawn up into the body, so not seeing them does not prove a female. In very young hamsters that gap is the most reliable guide, and a vet can confirm it at the first checkup.

Why it matters

FACT	FIGURE
Pups weaned	About 20 days (as late as 3 to 4 weeks by some counts)
Able to breed	7 to 8 weeks old
Pregnancy	16 to 19 days
Litter size	An average of nine pups

A pair of dwarfs sold as two females that turns out to be a male and a female can produce a litter before anyone has checked. Confirm the sex, and have a second cage ready regardless.

FIGHTS AND BITE WOUNDS

Fights between cage mates happen at night, so both animals are checked for bite wounds every morning. An abscess, a pus-filled swelling from an infected bite, needs a vet.

WHAT THIS PACKAGE DOES NOT COVER

Breeding is not a goal of this package, and it does not cover the care of a nursing mother. The facts above are here so a surprise litter is not a surprise.

Torpor: cold, short days & telling it from death

The one seasonal problem a pet hamster has, and it looks like the worst outcome.

What it is

Below about 41°F (5°C), particularly with short days, a hamster can enter torpor, a hibernation-like state with minimal activity and little or no eating. It is distinct from true hibernation, which pet hamsters do not undergo. Torpor can look alarmingly like the hamster has died.

Why it is dangerous

A Syrian hamster does not fatten up first, so one that fails to wake periodically to eat will starve. That is why the floor is a hard one: keep the room above 41°F, and well above it, since the comfortable range starts at 65°F (18°C).

What to do

1. **Do not assume it has died.** A cool, still hamster in a cold room may be in torpor.
2. **Warm it gradually.** Gradual warming is the first response.
3. **Check the room reading.** A thermometer at cage height tells you how cold it really got.
4. **Watch it eat.** A hamster that has been that cold and still is not eating once warm is an appetite-loss case, so follow the hours table for a hamster that stops eating.

Seasonal checks

WHEN	DO THIS
Autumn	Move the cage away from windows and doors, which means drafts, and put a thermometer in the room at cage height.
Winter	Keep the room at 65 to 75°F (18 to 24°C) and above 41°F (5°C) at all times, including overnight and during an outage. Keep the bedding dry and the cage out of drafts.
Summer	Watch for the room passing 80°F (27°C). Move the cage to the coolest room and keep fresh water in front of it.

Is a hamster legal where you live?

Legal almost everywhere in the United States, with one ban and one unclear rule.

This page covers all 50 states, the District of Columbia and New York City, which has its own rules: 52 jurisdictions. A pet hamster is **legal with no permit in 50, barred in 1 and unclear in 1**.

WHERE	STATUS	THE RULE
Hawaii	Barred	The Syrian hamster is on the Restricted Animal List, Part A (Hawaii Administrative Rules § 4-71-6), which is for research and exhibition only. No route for a household and no pet permit.
Oregon	Unclear	The not-wild list (Oregon Administrative Rules 635-056-0020(14)) names the "Common Hamster, <i>Cricetus cricetus</i> ", a large wild European hamster, not the pet Syrian (<i>Mesocricetus auratus</i>). An unlisted mammal is barred by default (635-056-0130(1)). Pet hamsters are sold openly there, so the exemption plainly means the pet one, but ask the state wildlife agency before you buy.

Where the rule names a species

WHERE	WHAT THE RULE NAMES
California, Rhode Island	Golden hamsters and <i>Phodopus</i> dwarfs, both by name. California (Title 14 § 671) clears domesticated golden and dwarf races.
Arkansas, Connecticut, Maine, Massachusetts, Vermont	The golden hamster and at least one dwarf group, by name.
Alaska, Wyoming	The golden hamster only, on a closed list. Dwarfs are not named.
New Jersey	The golden hamster is on the exempt list (New Jersey Administrative Code 7:25-4.4). The dwarf <i>Phodopus</i> species fall under the separate rule at 4.5, not the exemption.
Colorado, Georgia, Kentucky, New York City, Utah	The Syrian or golden hamster, by genus or species.

Read strictly, a dwarf under a Syrian-only rule is not the animal it cleared. In practice a dwarf is rarely stopped, but if you want the paperwork to match, ask the state agency.

Legal with no permit: 50 jurisdictions

Alabama, Alaska, Arizona, Arkansas, California, Colorado, Connecticut, Delaware, District of Columbia, Florida, Georgia, Idaho, Illinois, Indiana, Iowa, Kansas, Kentucky, Louisiana, Maine, Maryland, Massachusetts, Michigan, Minnesota, Mississippi, Missouri, Montana, Nebraska, Nevada, New Hampshire, New Jersey, New Mexico, New York State, New York City, North Carolina, North Dakota, Ohio, Oklahoma, Pennsylvania, Rhode Island, South Carolina, South Dakota, Tennessee, Texas, Utah, Vermont, Virginia, Washington, West Virginia, Wisconsin and Wyoming.

In eleven of them and in Oregon, the state lets cities or counties be stricter, so check your local ordinance (a city or county law) too: California, Colorado, Illinois, Kentucky, Maryland, Michigan, Montana, North Carolina, Nevada, Ohio and Washington. Nevada's Clark County, Las Vegas and Henderson are all stricter than the state.

NOT LEGAL ADVICE

State legal status as of October 2026. This is a summary of state rules, read on 1 October 2026, and not legal advice. Rules change. Before you buy or move, check with your state wildlife agency and with your city or county.

Red flags & finding a vet

Hamsters are hardy for their size, but a short life means problems progress fast.

SPEED IS THE WHOLE PROBLEM

A hamster's metabolism runs fast, so a condition can go from a first sign to an emergency in hours, and a life of two years or so leaves little margin for a wait-and-see week. Find a vet who sees small mammals before you need one, and write the number on the emergency card.

See a vet the same day

WHAT YOU SEE	WHAT IT MAY BE
Watery diarrhea, or a wet, matted rear end	Wet tail. Do not wait to see if it improves.
Labored breathing, wheezing, discharge from the eyes or nose	Respiratory infection.
A swollen abdomen	See a vet now.
Seizures	See a vet now.
A hunched, lethargic posture	A sick animal. See a vet now.
One-sided cheek swelling that stays, face-pawing, drooling	Cheek pouch impaction.
Refusing available food for 12 to 24 hours, or any refusal with lethargy or diarrhea	Call the vet.
Panting, drooling, weakness in a hot room	Heat stress.
Diarrhea or appetite loss during or after antibiotics	A drug reaction. Call immediately.
Cool, still and apparently lifeless in a cold room	Possibly torpor rather than death (page 22).

Book promptly

WHAT YOU SEE	WHAT IT MAY BE
Dropped food, drooling, weight loss	Overgrown incisors.
A lump or growth anywhere	Tumor, common in older hamsters, females especially.
Excessive drinking and urination with weight loss	Diabetes, more common in dwarf species.
Fur loss, irritated skin, heavy dandruff, visible mites	Parasites, or a skin problem.
Sunken eyes or a skin tent	Dehydration.
Sudden weight loss	Many causes. Bring the log.

FINDING THE VET

Ask a prospective clinic how many small-mammal patients it sees in a typical month, and keep a backup 24-hour emergency option too. A vet who answers confidently and specifically is telling you something useful before there is an emergency. Take the hamster in a hard-sided, ventilated carrier with bedding from its own cage (page 38).

Wet tail

Proliferative ileitis. The condition every hamster owner needs to recognize on sight.

A SAME-DAY EMERGENCY

Wet tail can be fatal within 24 to 48 hours without treatment. Do not wait to see if it improves. Get to a vet immediately.

Why it has its own page	A large veterinary study of 4,504 pet hamsters under veterinary care in the United Kingdom found wet tail in 7.33% of them, the most common specific diagnosis in the species, and the leading recorded cause of death at 6.27%.
Cause	Bacterial, and tied to stress. Stress, transport, overcrowding, poor hygiene or a sudden diet change are the usual triggers. It hits young Syrians of 3 to 10 weeks hardest.
Signs	Watery diarrhea, a wet or matted rear end, lethargy and a hunched posture. Appetite loss is an early sign.
Response	A vet at once. Treatment involves an antibiotic, and the choice matters in a hamster (page 29).

Not a single disease

The study's authors note that wet tail is frequently used in primary-care practice as a catch-all term for a soiled rear end in hamsters, from several sources, including diarrhea or urinary and reproductive tract discharge. It describes what the rear end looks like rather than naming one cause. That is a reason to get a wet-bottomed hamster seen, not a reason to diagnose it yourself.

Prevention is mostly the first weeks

- Keep the first days quiet: leave a new hamster alone for 24 hours, then start gently.
- Keep the diet it came on, and change anything over about ten days.
- Spot-clean the soiled corner daily instead of leaving it to a weekly strip-out.
- Never house two Syrians together, since overcrowding is on the trigger list.
- Look at the rear end whenever you handle it.
- Keep handling gentle and the environment calm. Rough handling and a stressful setting are part of the picture.

CHECK THE REAR END BY LOOKING

A vet checks the area under the tail for stains or discharge, and so can you at every handling session. In a long-haired hamster the wetness can be less obvious, so look rather than assume.

WHAT THE VET VISIT COSTS

An emergency exam runs about \$200 before any tests or treatment, and some hospitals add an after-hours fee. It is the cost most worth budgeting for.

Overgrown incisors & cheek pouch problems

Two mouth problems that both show up as a hamster that will not eat.

Overgrown incisors (malocclusion)

Cause	A hamster's teeth grow continuously and are worn down by chewing. A lack of appropriate chew items is the usual reason they overgrow, and less commonly a genetic or jaw problem.
Signs	Dropped food, drooling and weight loss. Overgrown teeth lead to pain and difficulty eating, so a hamster may avoid food while hungry.
Healthy teeth	The front teeth light yellow, smooth and wearing evenly.
Response	A vet, for trimming. It is not a home job.
Prevention	Appropriate chew items in the cage, and timothy hay as a chewing supplement.

THE MOST COMMON REASON A HAMSTER STOPS EATING

Dental problems are the single most common cause of appetite refusal. Weighing the hamster regularly catches it early, because a hamster in mouth pain loses weight.

Cheek pouch problems

A pouch full of food swells the face on either side and can look like a growth, but it is normal and empties again. A hamster's pouches stretch back as far as the shoulders, and impaction is one of the conditions a vet looks for, so the mouth is checked for impacted pouches and overgrown teeth together.

Cause	Uncommon, but soft or moist food can clump and lodge in a pouch.
Signs	Swelling that stays on one side, face-pawing, drooling, and a sudden loss of interest in collecting food.
Response	A vet. Any of those signs needs one.

TELLING A FULL POUCH FROM A PROBLEM

A full pouch swells both cheeks and goes down once the hamster has stashed the food. A swelling that stays on one side, with drooling or pawing, does not.

Tumors, skin problems & diabetes

The conditions of age, of fights, and of sugar.

Tumors

Tumors are common in older hamsters, particularly females, and can grow quickly given how fast a hamster's metabolism runs. They are fairly common in an elderly hamster and one of the more frequent causes of death in an aging one. A lump anywhere always warrants a vet visit. Check for lumps, bumps and scabs during handling, and again when you weigh.

Abscesses, mites and skin problems

An abscess is a pus-filled swelling, usually from an infected injury or bite. Mites, fungal infections or allergies cause itching, redness and hair loss. Fur loss, irritated skin, heavy dandruff or visible mites need a vet, as does any lump or wound found at a health check. After a night's fight between cage mates, a morning check for bite wounds is the way an abscess is caught early.

Diabetes, more common in dwarfs

Who	More common in dwarf species. Campbell's and Chinese hamsters have a documented high susceptibility.
Signs	Excessive drinking and urination alongside weight loss, with appetite and energy changes.
Response	A vet. It is manageable with a vet-guided low-sugar diet.
Prevention	Avoid sugary treats, honey sticks and fruit-heavy diets as a matter of course. A plain formulated pellet or lab block as the diet base is the simplest way not to feed into the risk.

PLAN FOR THE OLD AGE

A hamster of 1.5 years or more already counts as elderly. From about 2.5 years expect overgrown nails, hair loss, more sleeping and drinking, and slower movement. A steady weight log makes every one of these changes easier to see.

THE HUSBANDRY PATTERN WORTH REMEMBERING

Stress and poor hygiene are directly linked to wet tail. Dusty or aromatic bedding causes respiratory problems. A sugar-heavy diet raises diabetes risk in dwarfs. All three are fully within an owner's control, and given how short a hamster's life already is, the basics matter even more than they would with a longer-lived pet.

Respiratory infection & heat stress

Both start with the air in the room and the bedding in the cage.

Respiratory infection

Sneezing, wheezing, labored breathing and discharge are the signs. Drafts, damp conditions and dusty bedding, sawdust, cedar or pine especially, are the usual causes. A thermometer and humidity gauge confirm the room is not running colder or damper than it should, and clean, dust-free paper bedding removes one of the most common triggers outright. Always see a vet for this.

Heat stress

A hamster does not sweat the way a person does and has no cooling equipment of its own, so the room is its whole climate system. Heat risk begins around 80°F (27°C). The signs appear in a rough order:

- 1. **Rapid or open-mouth breathing**, faster and shallower than normal.
- 2. **Excess drooling**, sometimes leaving the fur around the mouth wet.
- 3. **Weakness and reluctance to move**, a normally active animal becoming lethargic or hard to rouse.
- 4. **Severe signs**: tremors, convulsions, collapse or unconsciousness. A genuine emergency.

DO THIS IMMEDIATELY	DO NOT
Move the hamster to the coolest available room, with air conditioning or good airflow away from direct sun.	Plunge it into cold or ice water. That can send a stressed small mammal into shock.
Offer cool, not ice-cold, water. Do not force it.	Assume it will recover on its own once it looks calmer. Heat stress can look like it is resolving and then relapse.
Cool it gradually, with a cool, damp towel or a light wipe of cool water on the ears and feet.	Skip the vet. It is a genuine emergency, not wait-and-see.
Get to a vet immediately.	

DO NOT LEAVE IT IN A PARKED CAR

A closed car crosses into heat stress territory well before it feels uncomfortably warm to a person standing outside it. Never put the carrier in direct sun or a closed trunk.

Antibiotics: ask before the first dose

The same drug a dog gets can kill a hamster.

A hamster is a hindgut fermenter: it digests plant fiber by fermenting it in an enlarged gut full of bacteria, and that bacterial population is overwhelmingly gram-positive. Certain common antibiotics wipe it out, and toxin-producing *Clostridium* bacteria take over. The result is a fatal diarrhea called antibiotic-associated enterotoxemia. It is a well-documented reaction, not a rare allergy, and it looks a lot like the wet tail being treated. Hamsters can develop it three to five days after an antibiotic dose, with severe intestinal inflammation on top of the diarrhea.

The antibiotic classes to ask about

CLASS OR DRUG	DOCUMENTED RISK
Penicillins (penicillin, ampicillin, amoxicillin, amoxicillin-clavulanate)	Contraindicated in hamsters
Lincosamides (clindamycin, lincomycin)	Contraindicated in hamsters
Macrolides (erythromycin, tylosin)	Unsafe for rodents generally
Cephalosporins	The same gram-positive mechanism as penicillins
Bacitracin	Unsafe for rodents, including in topical ointments if licked
Streptomycin	On the do-not-give list for rodents

WHAT TO ASK

"Is this antibiotic one of the ones known to cause fatal diarrhea in this species, and have you prescribed it to this species before?" Any drug aimed at gram-positive bacteria carries the risk, so the mechanism matters more than the brand. A vet experienced with exotics has an answer at once. One who does not may need to look it up, and that is reasonable to ask.

If it happens

Any diarrhea, appetite loss or lethargy that starts during or shortly after an antibiotic course is not something to monitor overnight. It is a call-the-vet-now situation, and stopping the antibiotic is usually the first step the vet will want to take. Do not wait for the next scheduled dose. Route matters too: oral dosing carries more risk than an injectable form of the same drug, because it passes directly through the gut where the bacteria live.

ASK, DO NOT REFUSE

Small mammals get real bacterial infections that need real antibiotics, and an untreated infection kills too. The aim is only that the right drug is picked the first time, particularly at a practice that mostly sees dogs and cats.

Reading the signs, hydration & germs you can catch

A hamster hides illness, so the check does the noticing.

The routine health check

LOOK AT	WHAT YOU WANT TO SEE
Eyes	Clean, clear and bright, with no cloudiness or discharge.
Teeth	Front teeth light yellow, smooth and wearing evenly.
Coat and skin	Clean, with no fur loss, flaky skin, dandruff, scratches or wounds.
Breathing	No sneezing, wheezing or labored breathing.
Rear end	No stains or discharge.
Weight	Steady on the kitchen scale. An unexpected gain or loss is worth acting on.
Body	No lumps, bumps or scabs.

Hydration

A hamster drinks about 9 to 12 ml a day. Dehydration shows as dull, sunken eyes, slow movements, very concentrated urine (dark color and a strong odor) and a skin tent, skin that stays up when it is gently lifted. A bottle that has barely moved in a day, a blocked spout and a hot room are the first things to check.

Droppings and waste

Diarrhea is the sign to act on: watery stool, or a wet or matted rear end, is a same-day vet call because of wet tail. Diarrhea that starts during or after antibiotics is a call too, and so is any change in appetite alongside it.

Germs you can catch

Syrian hamsters have a reputation as carriers of lymphocytic choriomeningitis virus (LCMV), a virus that can cause neurological disease in people, and an infected hamster can look completely well and still pass it on for at least 8 months. The routine is the same for every small mammal: wash hands with soap and running water after handling the hamster or its bedding, keep it and its equipment out of the kitchen and anywhere food is prepared or eaten, and clean its supplies outside the home if you can. Children under 5 are more likely than anyone to get sick from small-animal germs, and a bite or scratch can spread germs even when it does not look deep.

LOG IT

Weight is the early warning that costs nothing. The Owner Log on page 40 has a column for it.

Setup checklist & targets

Essential setup checklist

- ☐ Enclosure with 700 to 775 sq in (4,500 to 5,000 cm²) of unbroken floor for a Syrian, about 600 sq in (3,900 cm²) for a dwarf (page 6)
- ☐ Wire bars no wider than 1/2 in (13 mm) for a Syrian, 1/4 in (6 mm) for a dwarf
- ☐ Dust-free paper bedding or aspen shavings, 6 in (15 cm) at the very least, 40 cm (about 15 in) where the cage allows (page 7)
- ☐ Solid wheel with no rungs: 8 to 11 in (20 to 28 cm) for a Syrian, 6 to 8 in (15 to 20 cm) for a dwarf (page 9)
- ☐ Dust-free, non-clumping sand bath in a heavy dish
- ☐ At least one hideout, and tunnels or connected cover
- ☐ Water bottle with a valveless sipper tube, never glass for a Syrian
- ☐ Food dish, and a plain complete pellet or lab block
- ☐ Chew items and timothy hay
- ☐ Digital thermometer and humidity gauge at cage height
- ☐ Kitchen scale that reads in grams
- ☐ Hard-sided, ventilated carrier (page 38)

Targets

TARGET	°F, IN OR SQ IN	°C, CM OR CM ²
Room temperature, held steady	65 to 75	18 to 24
Act: cold, torpor risk below	about 41	about 5
Act: heat stress risk above	80	27
Room humidity	40 to 60%	
Bedding depth, minimum / better / the study's burrow depth	6 / 8 or more / about 15	15 / 20 or more / 40
Water drunk a day	About 9 to 12 ml	
Adult Syrian weight	3 to 5 oz (85 to 140 g); dwarfs under 100 g	
Fresh food	Vegetables about 1 teaspoon a day, fruit about 1 teaspoon 3 times a week, together under about 10% of the diet	

Before your hamster comes home

- ☐ Cage fully set up, with the bedding at depth, before collecting it
- ☐ A handful of used, dry bedding from its old cage moved in
- ☐ The room reading checked with a thermometer, not by feel
- ☐ Cage in a quiet area, lights off at about the same time each night
- ☐ A local vet registered, and the number on the emergency card (page 32)
- ☐ The food it is already eating, bought in advance

Emergency & quick targets

CALL A VET NOW IF

Watery diarrhea or a wet, matted rear end (wet tail, fatal within 24 to 48 hours untreated) · labored breathing or wheezing · discharge from the eyes or nose · a swollen abdomen · seizures · a hunched, lethargic posture · refusing food 12 to 24 hours, or any refusal with lethargy · dropped food or drooling · sudden weight loss · a lump or growth · a cheek that stays swollen on one side · panting and drooling in a hot room · diarrhea or appetite loss during or after antibiotics

READING	°F	°C
Room temperature, held steady	65 to 75	18 to 24
Out of range, appetite and activity drop below	65	18
Torpor risk below (warm it gradually)	about 41	about 5
Heat stress risk above (coolest room, cool damp towel on ears and feet)	80	27
Humidity	40 to 60%	
Without eating	6 to 12 hours watch · 12 to 24 hours call the vet · 24 hours critical · 48 hours life-threatening	

Your numbers

Vet who sees small mammals _____ Species and sex _____
 24-hour emergency clinic _____ Normal weight (g) _____
 Hamster's name and birth date _____ Last vet visit _____

HAVE THIS READY WHEN YOU CALL

The room reading, when it last ate and drank, its current weight and the trend, how the rear end looks, any antibiotic it has had, and what changed in the last few days. Take it in a hard-sided, ventilated carrier with bedding from its own cage (page 38).

ANTIBIOTICS

Before the first dose, ask whether the drug is one known to cause fatal diarrhea in hamsters. Penicillins and clindamycin are the best-known examples.

Budget: setup & shopping list

United States retail ranges, last checked October 2026 and rounded to the nearest \$5. Prices are a snapshot, not a quote.

INITIAL SETUP	TYPICAL COST
The hamster: a Syrian	about \$25
The hamster: a dwarf (Russian cheapest, Chinese, Winter White and Roborovski at the top)	\$15 to \$25
Enclosure for a Syrian: 700 to 775 sq in of unbroken floor (a bin, a wire cage with bars no wider than 1/2 in, a glass tank, or a 47-inch acrylic-and-metal cage of about 1,110 sq in); check the floor area before you buy	\$30 to \$250
Enclosure for a dwarf: a 40-gallon breeder tank (36 by 18 in, about 650 sq in) or a bin with the same floor; check the dimensions before you buy	\$30 to \$150
Solid exercise wheel for a Syrian, 8 to 11 in; check the diameter and that it fits the enclosure	\$25 to \$40
Solid exercise wheel for a dwarf, 6 to 8 in; check the diameter and that it fits the enclosure	\$15 to \$20
First load of paper-based bedding, 6 or more inches	\$15 to \$35
Hideout	\$10 to \$30
A burrow tunnel for connected cover	\$5 to \$15
Dust-free, non-clumping bath sand, in a heavy dish	\$20 to \$30
Heavy food dish	\$5 to \$10
Water bottle with a valveless sipper tube	\$5 to \$10
First bag of hamster pellets	\$5 to \$15
First set of chew toys and wood blocks	\$10 to \$20
First small bag of timothy hay, for chewing	\$5 to \$10
Digital thermometer and humidity gauge	\$10 to \$20
Kitchen scale that reads in grams	\$5 to \$15
Small hard-sided, ventilated carrier	\$10 to \$25
Setup total with a Syrian	\$185 to \$550
Setup total with a dwarf	\$165 to \$430

Each total counts one hamster, its enclosure and its wheel, plus every shared row. The bedding, pellet, chew and hay rows are the first supply; after that they move to the yearly table on the next page.

WHERE NOT TO CUT CORNERS

Enclosure first, bedding second, wheel third. They decide whether the animal thrives, and they are the three a starter kit gets wrong. Decor and novelty items are the cheap part and the last part.

Budget: yearly costs @ the vet

What a hamster costs to keep once the setup is in place, on the same rounding.

YEARLY ONGOING	TYPICAL COST
Hamster pellet or lab block top-ups	\$30 to \$50
Fresh vegetables, in small amounts	\$20 to \$40
Bedding replacement	\$60 to \$100
Chew toy and wood block top-ups	\$15 to \$25
Bath sand top-ups, a bag or two a year	\$10 to \$35
Timothy hay top-ups, a small bag or two a year	\$5 to \$15
Annual small-mammal wellness exam	\$80 to \$115
Yearly total, with the vet visit	\$220 to \$380
Without the vet visit, about \$10 to \$25 a month	\$140 to \$265

PLAN FOR, DON'T COUNT ON AVOIDING

An emergency exam, most urgently for wet tail, runs about \$200 before any tests or treatment, and some hospitals add an after-hours fee. A sick-animal exam costs a little more than a wellness exam.

WHERE THE MONEY GOES

Bedding is the largest yearly line, because a deep layer is replaced regularly to stay clean and dust free. Food is the smaller share, since a hamster eats little.

First 30 days

Before day 1

- ☐ Cage set up at depth, with used, dry bedding moved in (page 31)
- ☐ A local vet registered, and the emergency card filled in (page 32)

Day 1 to 2

- ☐ Leave it alone for the first 24 hours apart from food, water and a look for signs of illness or injury
- ☐ Keep it on the food it came on, and note the room reading
- ☐ Look at the rear end and watch for diarrhea, the earliest wet tail sign (page 25)
- ☐ Give the vet the medical record you were handed, and ask them to confirm the sex

Week 1

- ☐ Rest a hand in the cage in the evening, without touching (page 16)
- ☐ Spot-clean the soiled corner daily, and leave the nest and the hoard in place (page 10)

Weeks 2 to 3

- ☐ Floor sessions in a secure room, with a short tunnel, ending while it is calm
- ☐ Weigh it and start the Owner Log (page 40)
- ☐ If it is a young Syrian, keep the environment calm through the 3 to 10 week window

Week 4

- ☐ Short lifts: cup it up and set it back down. Most hamsters are happy to be picked up and handled after one to two weeks of this
- ☐ Do the first full clean if the cage is small, or spot-clean if it is large and deep
- ☐ Review the weight trend
- ☐ Fill in the pet-sitter sheet before you need it (page 39)

Weeks 5 to 8

- ☐ Add enrichment from the priority order (page 42)
- ☐ Check the sex again if there is any doubt, before 7 to 8 weeks of age

Symptom quick reference

Find what you see, then act on the right-hand column. When in doubt, call.

WHAT YOU SEE	LIKELY CAUSE	ACT
Watery diarrhea, wet or matted rear end	Wet tail	Vet today, immediately (page 25)
Labored breathing, sneezing, discharge	Respiratory infection	Vet. Check bedding dust and room dampness (page 28)
Dropped food, drooling, weight loss	Overgrown incisors	Vet for trimming (page 26)
Cheek swollen on one side, face-pawing	Cheek pouch impaction	Vet
A lump or growth	Tumor, abscess	Vet
Excess drinking and urination, weight loss	Diabetes	Vet. Cut sugary foods (page 27)
Fur loss, irritated skin, dandruff	Mites, fungus, allergy	Vet
Sunken eyes, slow movement, dark urine, skin tent	Dehydration	Check the water bottle and room, then vet
Panting, drooling, weakness	Heat stress	Coolest room, cool damp towel on ears and feet, vet now
Cool, still, in a cold room	Torpor	Warm it gradually, then vet (page 22)
Diarrhea or no appetite on antibiotics	Drug reaction	Call the vet immediately (page 29)
Chewing the cage wire	Shallow bedding	Deepen the bedding (page 7)
No food seen for a day, otherwise active	Working through a cache	Check the cache, then use the hours table
A bite	Startled hamster	Change the approach (page 16)
Fighting or bite wounds	Cage mates	Separate permanently, vet for wounds (page 19)

Daily, weekly & seasonal routine

Do it in the evening, once the hamster is up.

Daily

- ☐ Remove soiled bedding and uneaten fresh food
- ☐ Wash and rinse the water bottle or bowl, check the sipper, and refill
- ☐ Feed the staple, or top up the bowl if it is always available
- ☐ About 1 teaspoon of fresh vegetables, scattered or hidden
- ☐ Look at the rear end, the eyes and how it moves
- ☐ Read the thermometer, and check the room is not above 80°F (27°C)
- ☐ A short handling session if it is awake and calm

Weekly, and regularly

- ☐ Weigh it and write the number in the log
- ☐ Check eyes, teeth, coat, breathing, lumps and the rear end
- ☐ Fruit about 3 times a week, about 1 teaspoon
- ☐ Treats, 1 to 2 times a week at most
- ☐ Small cage: move it to a carrier and give the cage a full clean. Large deep cage: spot clean only

Every few weeks

- ☐ Large deep-bedded enclosure: a full clean, with the nest and hoard set aside and returned
- ☐ Replace the sand when it clumps or smells, and sift it at spot cleans
- ☐ Check the bedding depth has not packed down below 6 in (15 cm)

Seasonal

- ☐ **Autumn:** move the cage from windows and doors, and put the thermometer at cage height
- ☐ **Winter:** keep the room 65 to 75°F (18 to 24°C), never near 41°F (5°C), including overnight
- ☐ **Summer:** coolest room, fresh water, watch for 80°F (27°C)

Yearly

- ☐ A small-mammal wellness exam, \$80 to \$115
- ☐ Review the log, and the sitter sheet, for anything that changed

DO NOT

Strip the whole cage out, dig out the burrow, or reach in while it sleeps.

Power outages, heat waves, travel & transport

Power outage

An outage takes the air conditioning, the fan and the heat at once. The thresholds do not move: 80°F (27°C) is the heat line and about 41°F (5°C) the cold one. You are now the climate system. Keep fresh water in front of the hamster and keep feeding it.

Summer: freeze bottles of water so it can lie up against them, use cool wet towels, shade any open side with cloths, darken windows against direct sun, and put water in more than one container. Cucumber, melon and apple help. Move the cage to the coolest room, such as a tiled bathroom or a basement, add whatever air movement you can, and check the thermometer rather than guessing.

Winter: the problem is drafts and damp, not the thermometer. Keep the cage in a draft-free spot away from windows and doors, off the floor, keep the bedding dry, and check the water has not frozen.

Relocate once the room stops responding and you cannot bring it back: a friend's house, a relative's basement, or a vet with power. Decide at hour two, not hour eight.

Heat wave

The same plan as a summer outage. Heat stress starts with rapid or open-mouth breathing and drooling, and the first sign, not the fourth, is the point to move. Cool gradually, and never plunge it into cold or ice water.

Transport to the vet

- A sturdy, rigid, ventilated, hard-sided carrier the animal cannot chew through, with room to lie down and turn around. A wire cage is a poor travel choice.
- A hiding place inside, such as a towel over the carrier or a small tunnel, and a handful of clean bedding from its own cage.
- Strap it in with a seatbelt, or wedge it in the footwell, with a side facing the direction of travel.
- A cool, well-ventilated car. Never direct sun, never a closed trunk, and never a parked car, even briefly.
- A hamster travels alone. Keep the trip short, and choose a vet close to home where you can.

Travel without the hamster

Fill in the sitter sheet and walk the sitter through it once in person. The hamster stays at home, in its own cage, on its own routine.

FILL IN AND LEAVE BY THE CAGE

Pet-sitter sheet

Everything a sitter needs on one page. Walk them through it once in person before the first solo visit.

Hamster's name _____

Species and normal weight _____

My phone _____

Vet _____

24-hour emergency clinic _____

Backup contact _____

Each visit, in the evening

- ☐ Read the room thermometer. It should be 65 to 75°F (18 to 24°C). Call if it is near 80°F (27°C) or near 41°F (5°C).
- ☐ Water: wash and rinse the bottle, refill it, and check the sipper flows.
- ☐ Food: _____. About 1 teaspoon of vegetables: _____. Scatter it. Remove yesterday's uneaten fresh food.
- ☐ Remove soiled bedding only. Leave the nest, the burrow and the food hoard where they are.
- ☐ Look, from outside, at the rear end, eyes and breathing. Do not wake it.
- ☐ Do not reach in during the day while it is asleep.
- ☐ Do not offer grapes, onion, garlic, chocolate or anything not on the list: _____.
- ☐ Do not add a second hamster to the cage, ever.

CALL THE VET, THEN ME, IF

Watery diarrhea or a wet rear end · labored breathing · a swollen abdomen · seizures · not eating for 12 to 24 hours, or any refusal with lethargy · the room hot or cold. Wet tail is a same-day emergency.

Notes for the sitter

Where the food is _____

The sand bath is _____

Anything else _____

Owner log

A hamster hides illness, and an unexpected gain or loss in weight is often the first thing that changes. A hamster loses condition quickly once it is unwell, so a log turns a vague worry into a number you can read to the vet.

Equipment & vet log

Setup log

ITEM	DATE BOUGHT OR STARTED	LAST FULL CLEAN	NOTES
Enclosure (floor sq in)			
Bedding (depth in)			
Wheel (diameter in)			
Sand bath (sand replaced)			
Water bottle or bowl			
Thermometer and humidity gauge			

Vet and health log

DATE	VET	REASON	WEIGHT (G)	RESULT, MEDICINES, NEXT VISIT

WRITE DOWN EVERY ANTIBIOTIC

Record the name of any antibiotic the hamster has been given, and the date. If diarrhea or appetite loss follows, that note tells the vet at once what to stop.

Enrichment checklist & log

In priority order. Tick what is in place, and log what you try.

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ Bedding at least 6 in (15 cm) deep, 40 cm (about 15 in) or more where the cage allows | ☐ Scatter feeding instead of a bowl |
| ☐ A cage with the footprint and wall height to hold it | ☐ A sand bath, and a hideout |
| ☐ A solid wheel of the right size, with no rungs | ☐ Chew items, and timothy hay |
| ☐ Connected cover and buried tunnels | ☐ Novelty objects, last of all |

DATE	WHAT I ADDED OR CHANGED	WIRE-GNAWING SEEN?	HOW IT REACTED

READ THE LOG THE RIGHT WAY ROUND

Gnawing at the bars is a housing readout, and it fell as bedding depth rose. If it persists, deepen the bedding before you buy another toy. Heavy wheel running is not proof that things are right.

REFERENCE

Glossary, A to H

Abscess	A pus-filled swelling, usually from an infected injury or bite. Needs a vet. Page 27.
Bar spacing	The gap between the bars of a wire cage: no wider than 1/2 in (13 mm) for a Syrian and 1/4 in (6 mm) for a dwarf. Page 6.
Cache	A stash of food a hamster carries off in its cheek pouches and hides in the enclosure, also called a hoard. Page 12.
Cheek pouch	A stretchy pocket on each side of the mouth, reaching back to the shoulders, that holds roughly a fifth of the hamster's body weight in food. Pages 12, 26.
cm, cm²	Centimeter, and square centimeter: the metric units for length and for floor area. 1 in is 2.54 cm. Page 6.
<i>Clostridium</i>	Toxin-producing bacteria that take over the gut when an antibiotic wipes out the normal bacteria. Page 29.
Contraindicated	A drug a vet should not give to a particular animal because it is known to cause harm. Page 29.
Dehydration	Too little water in the body. Shows as dull, sunken eyes, slow movements, very concentrated urine and a skin tent. Page 30.
Dwarf hamster	The small species sold as pets: the Winter White, the Campbell's and the Roborovski. The Chinese hamster is sold alongside them but lives alone. Pages 5, 19.
Enterotoxemia	A fatal diarrhea caused by toxin-producing bacteria overgrowing in the gut, most often after certain antibiotics. Hamsters can develop it three to five days after a dose. Page 29.
°C, °F	Degrees Celsius and degrees Fahrenheit, the two temperature scales. 65 to 75°F is 18 to 24°C. Page 8.
g	Gram: the metric unit of weight a kitchen scale shows. 28 g is about 1 oz. Page 15.
Gram-positive	A large group of bacteria. A hamster's gut bacteria are overwhelmingly gram-positive, so antibiotics aimed at them can wipe the gut out. Page 29.
Hemolytic anemia	A shortage of red blood cells because they break down. The risk behind raw onion and raw garlic. Page 13.
Hindgut fermenter	An animal that digests plant fiber by fermenting it in an enlarged gut full of bacteria, as a hamster does. Page 29.
Humidity	The share of the moisture the air could hold, in percent (%). The target for the room is 40 to 60%. Page 8.

Glossary, I to Z

Impaction	A blockage. In a cheek pouch, soft or moist food that clumps and lodges there. Page 26.
in, sq in	Inch, and square inch: the units for length and floor area in this book, each with the metric figure beside it. Page 6.
Incisors	The front teeth. A hamster's grow continuously and are worn down by chewing. Page 26.
IUCN	International Union for Conservation of Nature, which keeps the global list of threatened species. The wild Syrian hamster is listed as Endangered. Page 4.
Lab block	A formulated, complete diet pressed into a hard block, nutritionally complete and something to gnaw. Page 11.
LCMV	Lymphocytic choriomeningitis virus: a virus Syrian hamsters have a reputation for carrying, which can cause neurological disease in people. Page 30.
Malocclusion	Teeth that no longer meet properly, so they overgrow. Page 26.
Mites	Tiny skin parasites that cause itching, redness and hair loss. Page 27.
ml	Milliliter: a metric unit of liquid, about a fifth of a teaspoon. A hamster drinks about 9 to 12 ml a day. Page 14.
mm	Millimeter, a tenth of a centimeter: the unit for bar spacing. Page 6.
Nocturnal	Active at night. A hamster is mainly nocturnal, so it sleeps by day. Page 16.
oz	Ounce: about 28 g. A Syrian weighs 3 to 5 oz. Page 15.
PDSA	People's Dispensary for Sick Animals, a United Kingdom veterinary charity whose hamster advice is among this package's sources.
Proliferative ileitis	The medical name for wet tail. Page 25.
Rex	A curly coat variety, one of several coat types. Page 5.
RSPCA	Royal Society for the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals, a United Kingdom animal welfare charity whose hamster pages are among this package's sources.
Sand bath	A dish of dust-free, non-clumping sand a hamster rolls in to work coat and skin oils out. A species essential. Page 9.
Scatter feeding	Scattering or hiding food around the cage instead of serving it in a bowl, which encourages natural foraging. Page 12.
Sipper tube	The spout of a water bottle. A valveless one has no ball inside, so a hamster can drink from it easily. Page 14.
Skin tent	Skin that stays up after being gently lifted, a sign of dehydration. Page 30.
Syrian	<i>Mesocricetus auratus</i> , the golden or teddy bear hamster. The largest and easiest to handle, and strictly solitary. Pages 5, 19.
Torpor	A cold-induced, hibernation-like state, below about 41°F (5°C), with minimal activity and little eating. It can look like death. Page 22.
Tumor	A growth. Common in older hamsters, particularly females, and growing fast. Page 27.
UVB	Ultraviolet B: the part of sunlight reptiles need for bone health. A hamster needs none. Page 8.
VCA	Veterinary Centers of America, now VCA Animal Hospitals: an animal hospital chain whose pet care articles are among this package's sources.
Vet	Short for veterinarian, an animal doctor. Page 24.
Wet tail	A bacterial gut infection tied to stress, with watery diarrhea and a wet, matted rear end. A same-day emergency. Page 25.
Wire-gnawing	Chewing the cage bars. A standard behavioral measure of housing quality in small rodents. Page 7.

REFERENCE

Sources

Where the numbers in this package come from, so you can check them yourself.

Veterinary references

- Merck Veterinary Manual: Hamsters (biology, husbandry, physical examination, infectious diseases, tumors and zoonotic risk), and Providing a Home for a Hamster. The weaning age, breeding ages, adult weights, the 41°F hibernation line, bedding depth, glass water tubes, the rear-end check and LCMV.
- LafeberVet: Basic Information Sheet: Hamster, and Sexing or Gender Determination in Small Mammals. The humidity target, water intake, weights, cheek pouch impaction and the sexing method.
- VCA Animal Hospitals (Veterinary Centers of America): Owning a Pet Hamster, and Feeding Rodents. Daytime activity, pouch caching, escaping, the wheel and what makes a hamster bite, and the feeding figures.
- Chicago Exotics Animal Hospital: hamster care. Dehydration signs and a full cheek pouch mistaken for a growth. Dial A Vet: hamster health and diseases. Abscesses, mites, diabetes and overgrown teeth.
- Exotic practices that publish their fees: Erlanger Veterinary Hospital and Colorado Exotic Animal Hospital. The wellness and emergency exam fees.

Research

- O'Neill and colleagues (2022), Journal of Small Animal Practice 63(10): demography, disorders and mortality of pet hamsters under primary veterinary care in the United Kingdom in 2016. The median age at death of 1.75 years, the wet tail figures and the aging changes.
- Hauzenberger, Gebhardt-Henrich and Steiger, Applied Animal Behaviour Science: the influence of bedding depth on behavior in golden hamsters. The 80, 40 and 10 cm groups and the wire-gnawing result.

Public health

- Centers for Disease Control and Prevention: Healthy Pets, small mammals. Hand washing, keeping animals out of the kitchen, and the higher risk to children under 5.

Husbandry and welfare references

- Royal Society for the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals (RSPCA): the hamster behavior, company, diet and health pages, and the taking-your-new-hamster-home sheet. Pickup, the dwarf group conditions, the first 24 hours, the ten-day diet change, cage placement and the exercise-ball warning. Prices were last checked in September 2026.
- Woodgreen Pets Charity: the introduction to hamsters and the health check pages. Species temperament, taming steps and what to check in a hamster.
- PetMD: the hamster lifespan page, the five most popular hamster breeds, and the Syrian hamster care sheet. Lifespan and length by species. People's Dispensary for Sick Animals (PDSA): hamsters as pets. Cleaning frequency.
- Merck Veterinary Manual: Lincosamides Use in Animals; VCA Animal Hospitals: Health Problems in Rodents; University of Missouri College of Veterinary Medicine: antibiotic-induced enterotoxemia. The antibiotic classes, the three to five day window and the heat line. RSPCA transport pages: the carrier and car rules.

The law

- Hawaii Administrative Rules § 4-71-6; California Code of Regulations Title 14 § 671; District of Columbia Code § 8-1808(j); Alaska Administrative Code title 5, section 92.029; Rhode Island Rules and Regulations Governing the Importation and Possession of Wild Animals; New Jersey Administrative Code 7:25-4; Oregon Administrative Rules 635-056; Wyoming, Georgia, Kentucky and Colorado rules on domestic or exempt animals; and each other state's rules, read on 1 October 2026.

REFERENCE

Where the sources disagree

Where credible sources give different numbers, this package prints one and says why.

TOPIC	WHAT THE SOURCES SAY	WHAT THIS PACKAGE USES
Feeding schedule	Pellets always available, since hamsters hoard and rarely overeat (veterinary sources); twice-daily measured meals of about 2 tablespoons, 1 for a dwarf, or 1/8 to 1/3 cup (feeding charts)	Either. Pick one and stay consistent
Hours without eating	A 6, 12, 24 and 48 hour ladder (a hobby care site); any refusal of available food is a vet call (veterinary sources)	The ladder, with a vet call as the floor
Weaning age	About 20 days (a veterinary manual); 3 to 4 weeks (a clinical information sheet)	About 20 days, noting 3 to 4 weeks
Room temperature	64 to 79°F (a veterinary manual); 68 to 75°F (a clinical sheet); 64 to 70°F (a welfare charity)	65 to 75°F, with 80°F as the heat line
Torpor and hibernation	Often hibernate below 41°F (a veterinary manual); pet hamsters generally do not, because homes are warm all year (a welfare charity)	Keep the room above 41°F, and treat a cold, still hamster as possible torpor
Dwarfs living together	All species live alone (a welfare charity); a same-sex pair or trio, formed young, can work (other charities and a veterinary site)	Alone is the safe default; shared only under the narrow conditions on page 19
Citrus	Avoid it entirely; occasional citrus is fine for a Syrian	Leave it out
Cooked onion and garlic	Raw is dangerous; a couple of sources say small cooked amounts are lower-risk	Never raw, and treat cooked as unconfirmed
Adult Syrian weight	110 to 140 g (a veterinary manual); 85 to 130 g (a clinical sheet); 90 to 140 g (a veterinary site)	3 to 5 oz (85 to 140 g)
Lifespan	Roborovski 2 to 3 years in one article and up to 4 in another; Winter White about 12 months or 1 to 3 years	The lifespan page's figures, with a median of 1.75 years
Bedding depth	At least 6 in, 8 or more better (a veterinary manual); 40 cm and up in the bedding study	6 in as the floor, 40 cm (about 15 in) as the target
Wet tail figure	"Roughly 7 to 8%" in summaries; 7.33% diagnosed and 6.27% of deaths in the study	The study's exact figures

REFERENCE

Version history & about

What changed in each edition, so a printed copy can be placed.

Version history

This is edition 3.0 (Oct 2026). The store page shows the current edition; re-download free if yours is older. Where this list and a page disagree, the page wins.

- **3.0, Oct 2026.** Rebuilt on the current outline, 47 pages. Safety: weaning about 20 days (3 to 4 weeks in one reference); a new hamster left alone 24 hours; Chinese hamsters live alone; spot-clean daily, full clean weekly for a small cage or every few weeks for a deep one, nest and hoard returned; adult Syrian 3 to 5 oz (85 to 140 g); humidity 40 to 60%; water 9 to 12 ml a day, no glass tube for a Syrian; wet tail fatal within 24 to 48 hours untreated; protein target figure removed. Legal: 48 states, the District of Columbia and New York City legal, Hawaii barred, Oregon unclear; some states name only the Syrian. Costs: every item priced and rounded to the nearest \$5; setup \$165 to \$550 with the animal (\$185 to \$550 with a Syrian, \$165 to \$430 with a dwarf); \$10 to \$25 a month, \$140 to \$265 a year before the vet; wellness exam \$80 to \$115; the budget now over two pages. Other changes are wording only.
- **2.3, Sep 2026.** Legal: Oregon added, rule unclear, so ask the state wildlife agency before buying.
- **2.2, Sep 2026.** Safety: torpor line 41°F (5°C), short days a further trigger; heat ceiling 80°F (27°C); antibiotic never-give list; fatal diarrhea three to five days after a dose. Other changes are wording only.
- **2.1, Sep 2026.** Tightened from 42 pages to 36, with no husbandry figure, red flag or target changed.
- **2.0, Sep 2026.** Rebuilt, 42 pages, with bedding depth, species choice, wet tail and torpor on their own pages. Replaced by 3.0.
- **1.0, Sep 2026.** First edition, 22 pages. Replaced by 2.0.

This package is a husbandry reference compiled from the listed sources and cross-checked against current veterinary guidance at the time of publication. It is not a substitute for a veterinarian who sees small mammals, and nothing in it should delay a vet visit, which for this species means the same day rather than the same week. Treatments described here are for recognizing what a vet may do, never for use at home. The law page is a summary as of October 2026, not legal advice.

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